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THE POLITICS OF POLICYMAKING IN TRANSITIONAL GOVERNMENT

A Case Study of the Ethnic Peace Process in Myanmar

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In a country such as Myanmar, which has long been in a constant state of civil war, there is no better reform agenda for a new government than negotiations with armed opponents. Given the long history of military rule in Myanmar, where fighting regularly breaks out between the Burman-dominated armed forces (Tatmadaw) and ethnic armed groups (EAGs), ethnic reconciliation has been one of the challenging tasks for successive governments. After the Tatmadaw's withdrawal from direct political rule in March 2011, the new quasi-civilian government placed persistent attention on the ethnic negotiation issue by bringing ethnic leaders to the table for peace talks. Unlike in the past, where the Tatmadaw (on behalf of both the military government and the armed forces) made ceasefire deals with the EAGs directly, the new peace